

Topaza pella

Crimson topaz

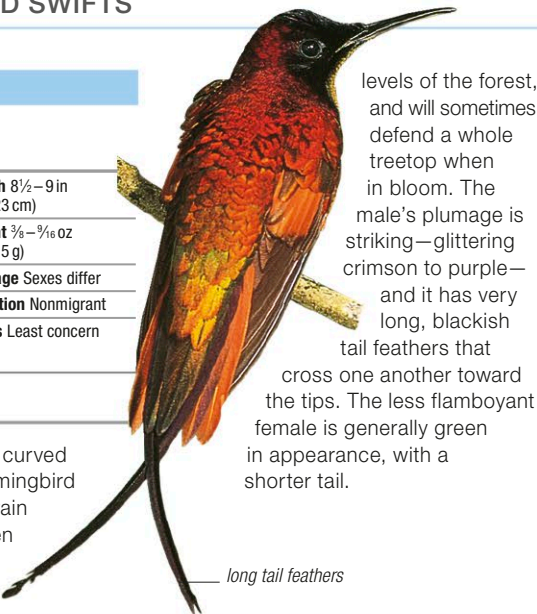


Location N. South America

Length 8½–9 in (21–23 cm)
Weight ¾–¾ oz (10–15 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



A relatively short, slightly curved bill allows this large hummingbird to feed from a variety of rain forest flowers. Rarely seen on the ground, it lives in the middle and upper



levels of the forest, and will sometimes defend a whole treetop when in bloom. The male's plumage is striking—glittering crimson to purple—and it has very long, blackish tail feathers that cross one another toward the tips. The less flamboyant female is generally green in appearance, with a shorter tail.

Patagona gigas

Giant hummingbird



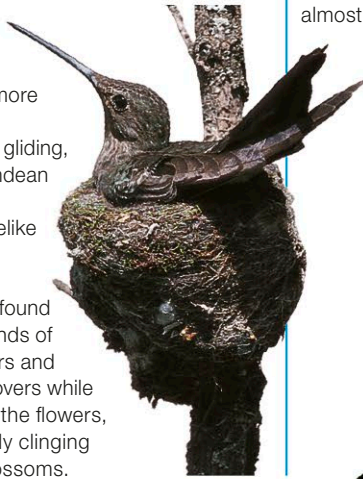
Location W. South America (Andes)

Length 8–8¾ in (20–22 cm)
Weight ¾–¾ oz (18–20 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



This species is the largest of all hummingbirds—even so, it weighs only 1½ oz (19 g). Its coloring is rather dull for a hummingbird: brownish overall

with pale rump feathers. It often flies more like a swift, sometimes gliding, over dry Andean valleys and arid, steppelike mountain slopes. Commonly found around stands of prickly pears and puyas, it hovers while feeding on the flowers, occasionally clinging to large blossoms.



Ensifera ensifera

Sword-billed hummingbird



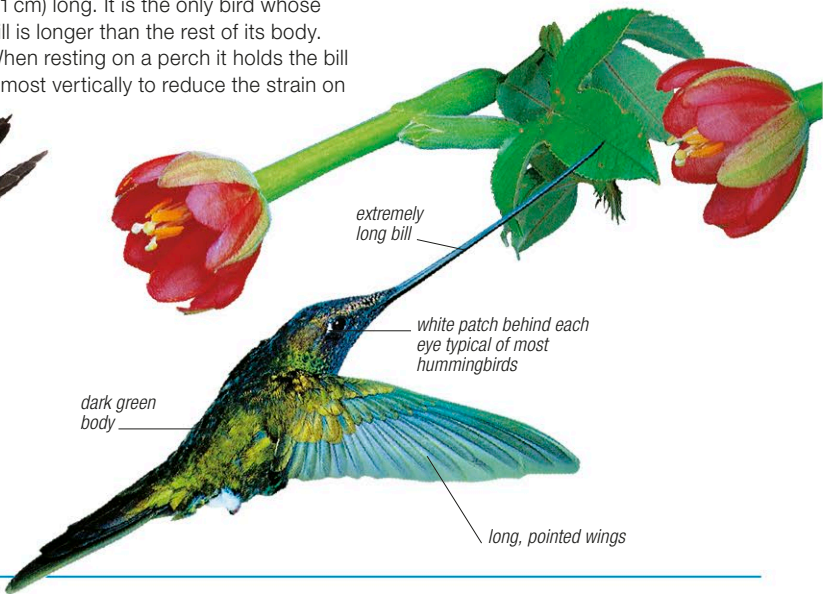
Location N.W. and W. South America (Andes)

Length 6½–9 in (17–23 cm)
Weight ¾–¾ oz (12–15 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Dark greenish in color, with a deeply forked, blackish tail, this bird has a slender, sword-shaped bill up to 4¼ in (11 cm) long. It is the only bird whose bill is longer than the rest of its body. When resting on a perch it holds the bill almost vertically to reduce the strain on

its neck. Apart from flying insects, which it catches by hawking with a wide-open bill, it feeds almost exclusively from flowers with very long tubes, such as brugmansias and daturas. These blossoms usually hang downward and the bird hovers immediately beneath, pushing the bill up into the flower to extract its nectar. This species follows a feeding strategy known as traplining. While some hummingbirds defend clumps of flowers from other birds and even butterflies, trapliners make regular visits to a number of scattered flowers, remembering where each one is and following a set route between them. The intervals between visits mean that the plants have a chance to produce more nectar.



Archilochus colubris

Ruby-throated hummingbird



Location S. Canada, C. and E. USA, Mexico to S. Central America

Length 3½ in (9 cm)
Weight ½ oz (3 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



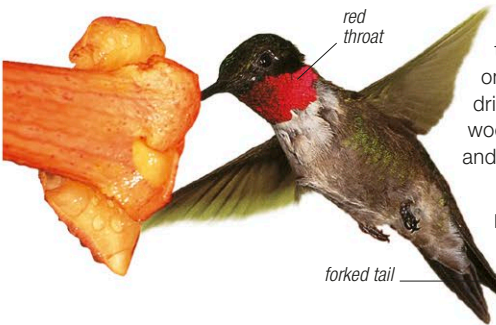
This is one of the few hummingbirds that migrate as far north as Canada, on an annual journey from Central America that may total over 1,900 miles (3,000 km). For some birds, migration involves a nonstop flight of about 530 miles (850 km) across the Gulf of

FEEDING THE YOUNG



Like other hummingbirds, this bird feeds its young largely on insects, because although nectar is a good source of energy, it does not contain enough protein for growth and development.

Mexico—a huge distance for such a tiny animal. This hummingbird feeds on nectar, and also uses the holes drilled in tree trunks by sapsucker woodpeckers to feed on tree sap and on the insects this attracts.

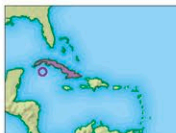


MALE AND FEMALE

A glittering red patch on the throat helps identify this small, iridescent green hummingbird; the female lacks the male's vivid coloring.

Mellisuga helenae

Bee hummingbird

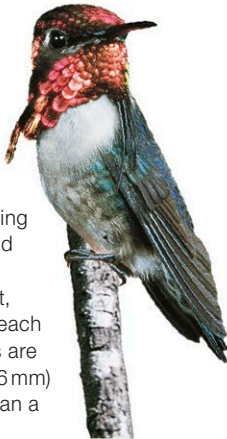


Location Cuba, Isle of Youth

Length 2–2¼ in (5–6 cm)
Weight ¼ oz (Up to 2 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened



The smallest of all birds, the male bee hummingbird weighs less than ¼ oz (1.6 g). It is green with a grayish white underside, and has an iridescent, fiery red head and bright collar. The female is slightly larger, weighing ¼ oz (2 g), and has no iridescence on the head or neck. This bird feeds mainly on nectar, hovering with its body held horizontally and pushing its short, straight bill into each flower. The eggs are as little as ¼ in (6 mm) long—smaller than a single pea.



Oreotrochilus estella

Andean hillstar



Location W. South America (Andes)

Length 5–6 in (13–15 cm)
Weight ¾–¾ oz (8–9 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Common in rocky slopes (with grass and scrub) at altitudes of up to 16,500 ft (5,000 m), this mountain bird does not hover in front of the flowers from which it feeds, but perches on them. Nocturnal torpor is very important for it because nights in the high Andes can be very cold, and the bird would not survive if it tried to maintain its body temperature at daytime level. The male's iridescent emerald-green collar with a black border distinguishes it from the female.

